Name: _____ Class: _____

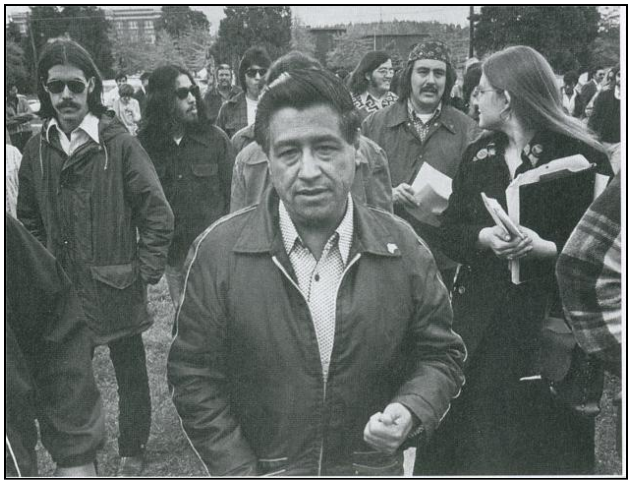
Sì Se Puede!

The Legacy of Cesar E. Chavez

By Carlos Lossada
2002

Cesar Chavez (1927-1993) was an American civil rights leader who was known for his fight for the rights of farm workers. On March 31, Chavez's birthday, many states in America celebrate Cesar Chavez Day. As you read, take notes on what Chavez believed in.

[1] **Sì se puede!** was a favorite saying of Cesar E. Chavez. In English, it means "It can be done!" or "Yes we can!"



"Cesar chavez visita a colegio cesar chavez" by Movimiento is licensed under CC BY-SA 3.0

Cesar E. Chavez was a man who believed that anything is possible. He is remembered for organizing the National Farm Workers Association (NFWA), for being president of the United Farm Workers of America (UFW), and for protecting the rights of farm workers. But as we celebrate Cesar Chavez Day each year, it is important to remember everything that he stood for: justice, equality, nonviolence, activism, respect for others, unity,[1] and education of the heart. These are the ideas that Chavez believed in. This is why we celebrate the life of Cesar E. Chavez.

Cesar E. Chavez believed that it does not matter whether you are poor or do not have much education. He believed that all people are important, no matter how much money they have or what color their skin is. Chavez spent his life fighting for others, but his fight was always peaceful and without violence. The idea of nonviolence was important to him. People should never use physical force to get what they want, he believed. To Chavez, violence only brings more violence and nobody wins. The only way to win is to have power. Real power is built when people work together. One of Chavez's strongest beliefs was that people who are united can never be defeated.

Cesar E. Chavez saw all people as equal and deserving of respect from others. There must be justice and fairness, he said. If something is not fair, it is a problem for everyone. You cannot stay quiet. You must be responsible and speak up. If an injustice is being done to someone else, you must stand up and act against it. Chavez believed that you will always be right if you are doing what is fair for all people.

1. **Unity** ***(noun):*** being joined or working together towards a common goal

[5] Chavez always continued his education. He read books on just about everything. He believed that it was important to educate your head and your heart. However, it is not enough to make ourselves better, he said. We must help others get better, too. We must understand other people's suffering, and we must work to help them. This is the only way that we will all be successful and free.

Cesar E. Chavez left us with his ideas. He will always be remembered as long as his ideas live on. We all win when we stand up against injustice. Anything is possible! Sì se puede!

"Sí Se Puede!: The Legacy of Cesar E. Chavez" from Appleseeds by Carlos Lossada. Copyright © 2002 by Carus Publishing Company. Reproduced by permission.

All Cricket Media material is copyrighted by Carus Publishing Company, d/b/a Cricket Media, and/or various authors and illustrators. Any commercial use or distribution of material without permission is strictly prohibited. Please visit http://cricketmedia.com/info/licensing2 for licensing and http://www.cricketmedia.com for subscriptions.

Text-Dependent Questions

Directions: For the following questions, choose the best answer or respond in complete sentences.

1. PART A: What is the main idea about Cesar Chavez in the text?
    A. Chavez believed in the fair treatment of all people and fought for it using non-violent actions.
    B. Chavez was concerned about farm workers' rights because he was once a farm worker.
    C. Chavez thought there was nothing more important than an education and spent his time reading.
    D. Chavez would have likely created greater changes in America if he had protested more violently.

2. PART B: Which detail from the text best supports the answer to Part A?
    A. “Sì se puede! was a favorite saying of Cesar E. Chavez. In English, it means ‘It can be done!’ or ‘Yes we can!’" (Paragraph 1)
    B. “Cesar E. Chavez was a man who believed that anything is possible. He is remembered for organizing the National Farm Workers Association (NFWA)…” (Paragraph 2)
    C. “He believed that all people are important, no matter how much money they have or what color their skin is. Chavez spent his life fighting for others, but his fight was always peaceful and without violence.” (Paragraph 3)
    D. “Chavez always continued his education. He read books on just about everything. He believed that it was important to educate your head and your heart. However, it is not enough to make ourselves better, he said.” (Paragraph 5)

3. Which of the following best describes how the information is organized in the text?
    A. The author compares Cesar Chavez’s beliefs with other well-known activists.
    B. The author discusses Cesar Chavez’s early life, and then discusses his later life.
    C. The author compares the people who liked and disliked Cesar Chavez.
    D. The author describes what Cesar Chavez is best known for, and then his personal beliefs.

4. How is Cesar Chavez’s favorite saying “sì se puede!” related to his work creating positive change?

Discussion Questions

Directions: Brainstorm your answers to the following questions in the space provided. Be prepared to share your original ideas in a class discussion.

1. In the text, the author discusses how Cesar Chavez rejected violence. Do you agree with his opinion that violence only leads to more violence? Why or why not? What other activists believed in peaceful protesting?

2. The author describes how Cesar Chavez fought for the fair treatment of all people. Do you think this makes him a hero? Why or why not? In your opinion, what makes someone a hero?

3. In the text, the author describes how Cesar Chavez fought for what he believed in. What is something that you believe in? What can you do to support this cause?